12 THE SCENT OF THE MADELEINE

Happy
and master of himself
is the man who
for every day of his life can say:
“Today I have lived;
tomorrow if God extends for us
a horizon of dark clouds
or designs a morning
of limpid light,
he will not change our poor past
he will do nothing without the memory
of events that the fleeting hour
will have assigned to us.” (III, 29)

Let us turn to ourselves, then, and to the role we play in relation to the nature of time. Above all else, what *are* we as human beings? Entities? But the world is not made up of entities, it is made from events that combine with each other . . . So what, then, am “I”?

In the *Milinda Pañha*, a Buddhist text written in Pali in the first century of our era, Nāgasena replies to the questions of King Milinda, denying his existence as an entity:[106]

> King Milinda says to the sage Nāgasena: What is your name, Master? The teacher replies: I am called Nāgasena, o great king; Nāgasena is nothing but a name, a designation, an expression, a simple word: there is no person here.

The king is astonished by such an extreme-sounding assertion:

> If no person exists, who is it then who has clothing and sustenance? Who lives according to the virtues? Who kills, who steals, who has pleasures, who lies? If there is no longer an actor, neither is there good or evil any longer.

And he argues that the subject must be an autonomous being that is not reducible to its component parts: